such high places with recommendations. My practice was to listen to the requests, some even bordering on ‘instructions’, ignore them and select the candidates on merit. And that is how I treated Sreekumar’s request. Being the commandant of CISF, our prime sentinel, I listened to him courteously and told him that if the candidate is good she will make it. Sreekumar left the room. When the selection list was out, Sreekumar came to me again.

‘You should’ve told me that you couldn’t get her the job,’ he said. Only then had I realised that the woman for whom he had recommended the job had not made it to the selection list. I explained to Sreekumar that as a matter of policy we just hear people out, but don’t act on recommendations. Several people would also call to thank us for giving someone a job. With equal nonchalance, we listen to such responses, often not telling them that their recommendation made no difference to the prospects of the candidate who was selected purely on merit.

He raised his voice. I raised mine. In normal circumstances, I should have reported to the CISF commandant about a ‘trespasser’ in my office. Now, the trespasser was the CISF commandant. Even as I stood wondering who to call, Sreekumar walked to the door, but turned to me and issued this threat, ‘You will pay for this.’

‘Get out,’ I shouted.

During my interrogation, Sreekumar would have enjoyed his petty revenge, but I am not sure if he knew about the bigger conspiracy some of his masters were privy to. Meanwhile, Siby was dancing to the tunes of Congress faction leader Oommen Chandy whose prime aim was to unseat Kerala Chief Minister K Karunakaran.

Siby, after his retirement, was rewarded by Chandy, then Chief Minister, with the post of the chief information officer in Kerala. Siby, like Sreekumar, has been pleading innocence, and blaming others for the fiasco in public. In private, however, Siby was at least once profusely apologetic to me for being part, inadvertently, according to him, of the conspiracy that ruined my career. And that was a secret meeting Siby must be trying hard to forget.